

neering and maths competitions that organisations/educational institutes conduct. Such initiatives are excellent opportunities to demonstrate creativity, secure mentoring opportunities from industry experts and participate in exciting, competitive and recognised events. Try engaging consistently with the institute/university faculty to understand sponsorship and scholarship opportunities offered by companies/universities."

He also feels that besides technical skills, students must possess excellent problem-solving and decision-making abilities, English communication skills, and organisation and management skills for an all-round perspective.

Mehra, in addition to these skills, emphasises on ethical behaviour as majority of the MNCs empower their staff and would like them to showcase good ethics while dealing internally or externally with vendors or customers.

Tip #3: Exploit your internship

Even if it is not compulsory in your course curriculum to do an internship, do one anyway. In fact, try enrolling for more than one if possible. Taking up a project or internship to build something is essential, as there is plenty of learning for the student to imbibe, whether the project succeeds or not.

"Colleges have included industry visits, seminars and projects for this purpose. Unfortunately, many students treat these courses lightly. My advice would be to take the internship seriously, for the soft skills they impart will be invaluable," advises Ravikumar.

According to Ahuja, industry-academia-government partnership will provide students with valuable practical experience while in college, by applying their theoretical knowledge to actual customer problems. The ecosystem needs to work together to constantly update the curriculum of educational institutes for it to be in line with the latest industry developments and encouraging internship programmes. This will impart hands-on technical, business and soft skills to

students in a professional environment and also give the company access to a potential workforce.

Keep in mind that "interning is about more than just showing up at an office and earning a recommendation letter," says Sanjay Mittal, managing director, Yogasa Systems. Grab every opportunity to chat with everyone from senior members to fresh recruits. You'll learn a lot about the industry, job and their expectations. It may help to join the same company after completing your course. In fact, interning is just like auditioning—you try the company to check whether it suits you.

Tip #4: Know the industry trend

"A fresh electronics engineer needs to be conversant with global trends and pioneering research done worldwide. To acquaint himself with the challenges that will face him in the future, the engineering student should re-examine and realign his goals with the current scenario that prevails. He should also keep himself abreast of recent trends in business and technology, if he is serious about making a transformational change," says Kumar.

Shetty feels that there is no alternative to on-the-job research. Students need to have some insights by either working or doing some research on how the industry segment of their choice actually operates.

"The electronics industry is very large today. There are multiple sub-disciplines. Even some software disciplines require a sound knowledge of electronics along with a strong grip on programming, e.g., electronic design automation. I would advise the engineering aspirants to become strong in fundamentals and take elective courses that give them the exposure to recent advances," says Ravi Kumar.

According to him, "Becoming a member of a professional society and taking active part in seminars and workshops will also help in understanding where the electronics industry is headed."

Kant adds, "Subscribe to important and insightful trade media journals and

newsletters to keep track of trends and latest developments in electronics engineering."

Keeping abreast of the industry and economy may even help you to find an extremely satisfying career outside the mainstream.

Tip #5: Understand your aptitude

Last, but the most important of all, don't follow the herd. "Since majority of the technical skills are quite well-founded within students, they need to match real-life practical applications, especially from a problem-solving perspective. Students should have the ability to assess the situation, identify key issues that need to be addressed, break down complex problems into simpler manageable problems and resolve the problem to develop workable solutions. Companies are looking for people who can fix problems with minimal direction. They don't want to have to tell people to react when fires are burning," says Mehra. So once you've understood your aptitude and carefully evaluated the job market, you can make your leap.

Further, Mehra advises that in their third or fourth year of engineering, the students should begin to think of what industry they wish to join and start digging into the relevant literature. If you are fortunate enough, you may get to do an internship in the industry of your choice.

In fact, there has been a spurt in various application fields of electronics engineering—defence, infrastructure (railways, aerospace, metro and telecom), biomedical, consumer appliances, industrial power, instrumentation engineering, automotive, etc. So once you figure out what is of your interest, work towards developing skills required for that vertical.

Finally, your future is in your hands. So don't hesitate to spend enough time exploring all the possible ways before final settlement. ●

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